

UAE: Iran detente falters, raising attack risk

送信者: EG Middle East & North Africa 受信日時: 2026-08-20 05:33

[【メール原文】](#)

The UAE suspended trade and commercial ties with Iran on 18 August after accusing Tehran of firing two ballistic missiles toward its territory. In a |||||

[Quick take](#)

[Customize Email Preferences](#)

Iran-UAE detente falters, raising risk of attacks on Emirates

19 Aug 2026 16:31 EDT [Discover more on the Portal](#)

What Happened

The UAE suspended trade and commercial ties with Iran on 18 August after accusing Tehran of firing two ballistic missiles toward its territory. In a later statement, Abu Dhabi said that the two ballistic missiles launched from Iran were targeting maritime navigation and fell into the sea.

Our Take

The unraveling Iran-UAE detente exposes Emirates to escalating Iranian attacks. About a month ago, the UAE quietly negotiated a detente with the Islamic Republic. Before the recent rupture, Tehran and Abu Dhabi maintained a direct and high-level diplomatic channel as well as alleged financial arrangement under which the UAE reportedly transferred frozen assets to the Iranian government (see: GCC states will establish detente while pursuing deterrence with Iran , 17 June 2026).

That arrangement is now falling apart. Over the past two weeks, Iran has resumed attacks on Emirati shipping because Abu Dhabi plays a key role in the shuttle trade that moves crude oil out of the Persian Gulf. So far, the deterioration in ties has been limited to attacks on Emirati shipping. However, Abu Dhabi's latest move increases the risk of Iranian attacks on UAE territory.

The UAE has shown that it can defend against Iranian attacks. Since the war began, Tehran has directed more attacks at the UAE than at any other country. Abu Dhabi has also strengthened its defenses in recent months and will likely be better positioned to withstand any renewed Iranian attacks.

The Emirati announcement may be the result of US pressure. The US probably pressed the UAE to cut trade as part of its new wait-and-see campaign to build economic pressure on Iran. The announcement came hours after a call between President Donald Trump and UAE President Mohammed bin Zayed, and amid new reports that the US is evaluating its defense presence throughout the region. Trump is also leveraging more direct pressure on other regional players to isolate Iran, threatening to bomb Oman if it conceded too much in its negotiations with Iran. Even so, the Iranian attacks probably made the Emirati leadership more receptive to US pressure.

Last week, Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said the Trump administration would unveil new measures against Iran as it seeks to increase economic pressure on Tehran to return to the negotiating table. The

economic effect of the Emirati announcement on Iran remains unclear since much of the business between the Persian Gulf neighbors flows through informal channels.

Firas Maksad

Managing Director, Middle East & North Africa

+1 202.552.5384

maksad@eurasiagroup.net

Farzan Sabet

Senior Analyst & Practice Manager, Middle East & North Africa

sabet.ne@eurasiagroup.net

Hussein Suleiman

Senior Analyst, Middle East & North Africa

suleiman.ne@eurasiagroup.net

Marc Gustafson

Managing Director, Analysis

+1 202.540.5144

gustafson@eurasiagroup.net

Clayton Allen

Practice Head, United States

+1 202.903.0027

allen@eurasiagroup.net

EG Middle East & North Africa

mena@eurasiagroup.net

© 2026 Eurasia Group. All rights reserved. This material was produced by Eurasia Group for use by the recipient. This is intended as general background research and is not intended to constitute advice on any particular commercial investment or trade matter or issue and should not be relied upon for such purposes. It is not to be made available to any person other than the recipient. No part of this publication may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic or otherwise, without the prior consent of Eurasia Group.

X-HG-DocID cmt0jmxuenzvs07myq6g4qmay

[Opt Out](#) | [Customize Email Preferences](#)